between 1993 and at least 2010, protests of various kinds, including mass incidents, increased. They may have peaked around 2010 and then declined. Still, 75,000 protests from 2013 to 2016 is a large number of disruptive events per year.

The question is: what kind of protests occur, and are they aimed at the government, particularly the central government and communist party rule? It appears that 70 per cent of the protests were related to labour, real estate, and land issues, with labour protests accounting for the largest segment.[29] The labour protests are apparently mostly over financial compensation, and they happen around the Chinese New Year when millions of workers go home to celebrate.[30] Real estate protests are between homeowners on one side and real estate developers and property managers on the other, over matters such as fraudulent dealings, delays in construction, poor quality of workmanship, and provision of utilities (for example, water, electricity). Land issues, particularly land-grabs, evictions, and relocations of people, are in decline as a cause of protest. Overall, protests are mostly in the cities, in the eastern part of China, and are small (involving between ten and 100 people), with an average of thirty people.[31]

A lot more needs to be known about protests in China. Scholars who study them acknowledge that the data is uneven and of questionable quality. From what is known, though, labour protests and homeowners' real-estate protests are the most significant. This would suggest that Chinese authorities could have a problem. The working population of China is massive, in the hundreds of millions, and nearly ninety per cent of Chinese urban households own the leasehold to their homes.[32] Labour protests plus homeowner protests could therefore be explosive. However, indications are that the majority of protests are non-political and therefore not a great threat. In addition, the central government has been able to manage the problem by acknowledging protester grievances, avoiding heavy-handed repression, and publicly calling for local and provincial authorities to 'temper' their response to the protests. As a result, protesters blame non-government entities or local governments for their difficulties, but they do not clamour for civil and political rights and they do not question the